and sufficient experience of service in the missile forces," recalled Sidorov.[14]

Statsenko's first task was to organize the unloading of the missiles, equipment, and accompanying personnel. Even more than with the SAMs, the key concern with the MRBMs was to ensure the secrecy of the operation. Statsenko later wrote: "The missiles were unloaded from the ships only at night, with the ships and ports fully darkened. While the missiles were being unloaded, the external approaches to the ports were guarded by a specially designated mountain rifle battalion of three hundred men transferred from the Sierra Maestra region." That was not all. "Within the defensive perimeter of the ports, there were the personnel of newly arrived subunits and groups of strategic operational officers assigned by the staff," continued Statsenko. "Navy ships and cutters protected the seaward approaches to the ships that were being unloaded, as did specially vetted and selected fishermen from among the local Cuban population. Every two hours, specially selected divers checked the submerged parts of ships and the harbor bottom near the piers."[15]

Once the missiles were unloaded, Statsenko's next task was to bring them to their places of deployment. He was in a hurry. The discovery of the SAMs by U-2 airplanes forced Khrushchev and the General Staff to revise the missile deployment schedules, cutting time needed for the transportation and installation of the missiles. According to the new timetable, regiments such as Sidorov's with R-12 launchers were supposed to be combat-ready by November 1, while the R-14 intermediate ballistic missile regiments were to prepare for combat between November 1, 1962, and January 1, 1963. The problem was that the missiles and accompanying equipment only began to reach Cuba on September 9. The arrival of all personnel, missiles, and equipment of Sidorov's regiment, the first to come to the island, was not completed until the first weeks of October. The situation with other regiments was even worse.[16]

Transporting the missiles to designated areas sometimes two hundred kilometers distant from the ports of disembarkation created numerous security problems. The columns moved only at night, between midnight and 5:00 a.m. To keep the itineraries and destinations secret, reported Statsenko, "when routes were closed, imitation car accidents were staged, with the